

Spinoza: substance and attributes



The Dutch philosopher Benedict Spinoza was a lens-maker by trade, with a comprehensive knowledge of not only optics, but also physics, astronomy and mathematics. As a philosopher, he was attracted to Descartes's rationalist epistemology, which fitted well with his own scientific thinking, but he did not agree with Descartes's mind-body dualism. Although he recognized that our rational thoughts are different from our physical senses, he could not accept that mind and body are separate, as they obviously interact, nor that there are two distinct mental and physical substances. Instead, in his book *Ethics*, he proposed a form of monism. Everything that

exists consists of this one substance but, Spinoza believed, also has both physical and mental attributes: the single substance is neither exclusively physical nor mental, but exhibits aspects of both. Spinoza's 'neutral monism' or 'property dualism' provided a solution to the problem of interaction between separate material and immaterial substances posed by Descartes's substantive dualism (see [Mind-body dualism](#)).